PORTFOLIO

SELECTED WORK 2025 - 2026

BRANDON NGUYEN

01 Geometric Abstraction 4

02 Totem 9

03 MFAH Library 13

04 External Systems 19

05 Internal Systems 23

06 Menil Extension 26

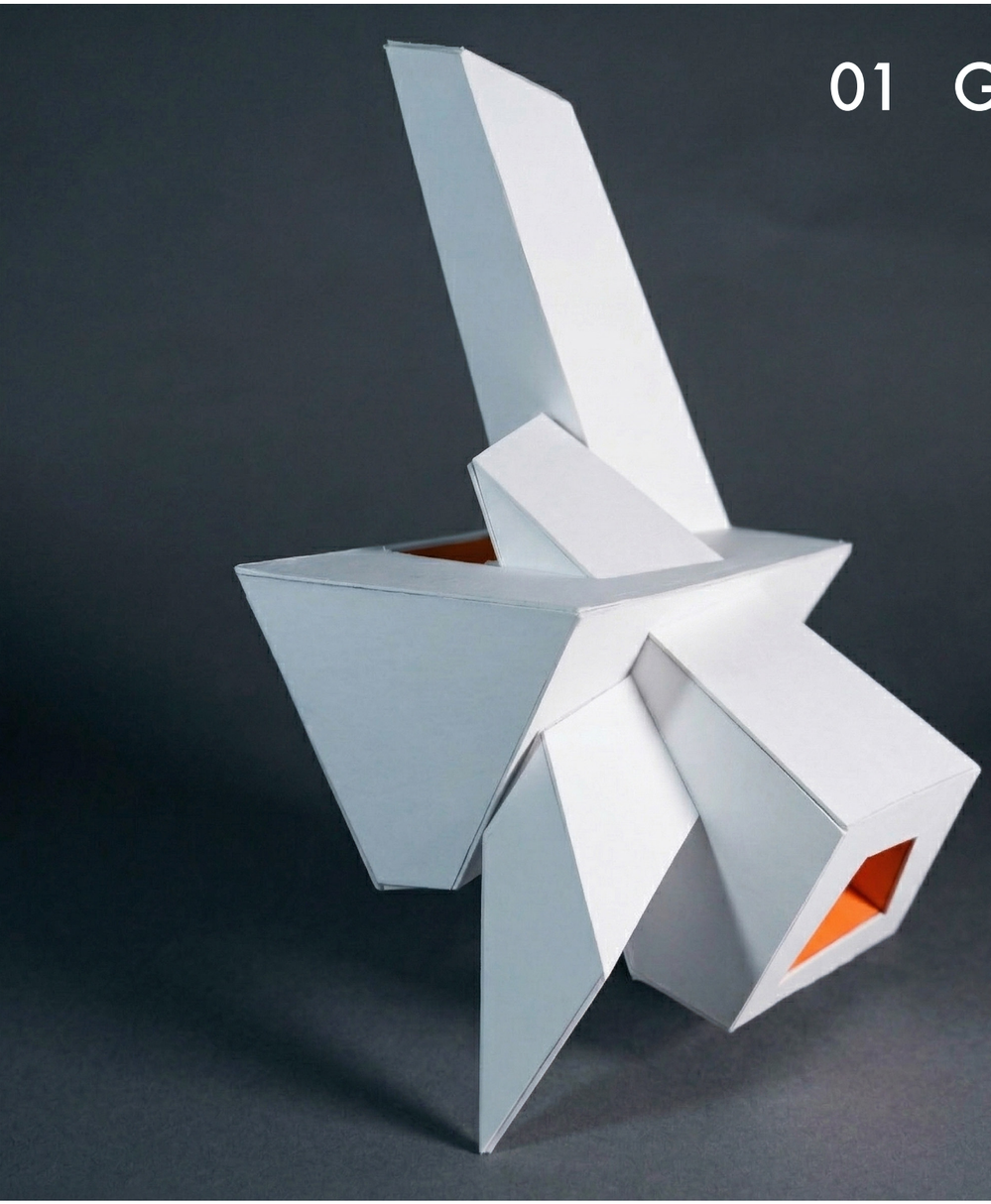
Brandon Nguyen

bn38@rice.edu
brandon.nguyen1249@gmail.com
(978)-888-7355

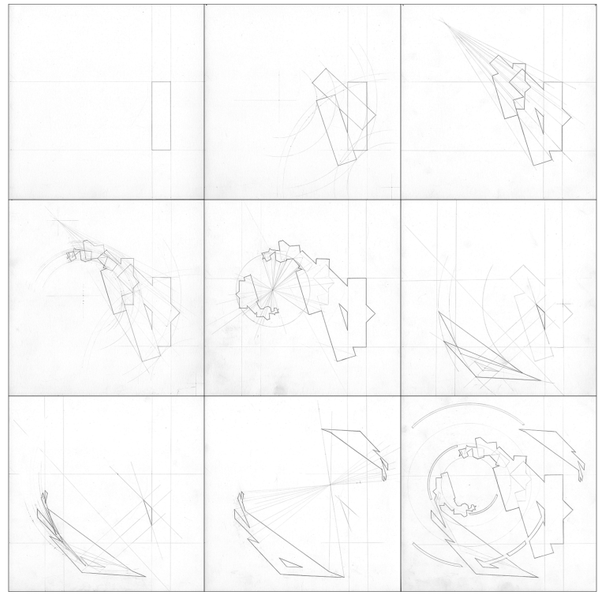
Houston | Boston

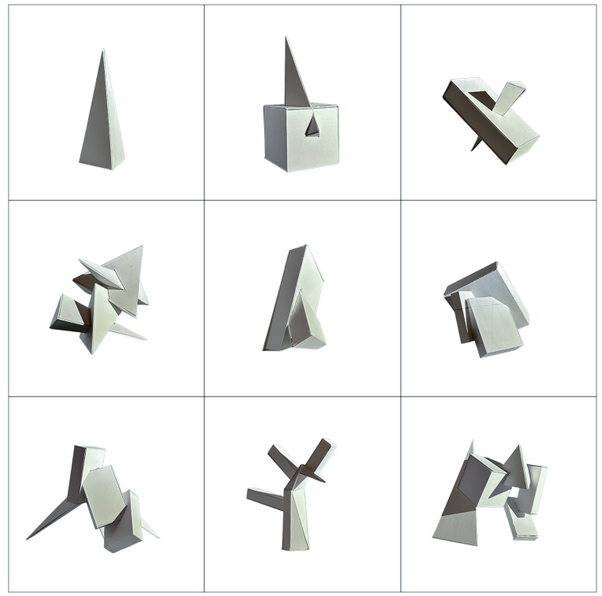
01 GEOMETRIC ABSTRACTION

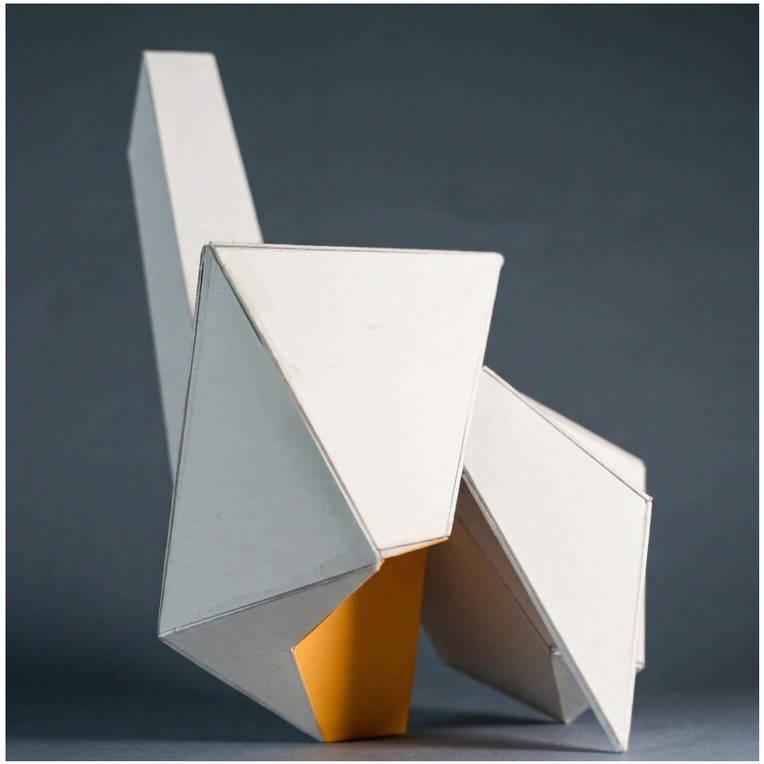
This project was produced through a series of physical models and drawings that grow in complexity over the length of the assignment. A series of nine drawings (top) kick-started the project. Derived from 3 rectangles and the triangular negative space between them, the final geometry emerges.



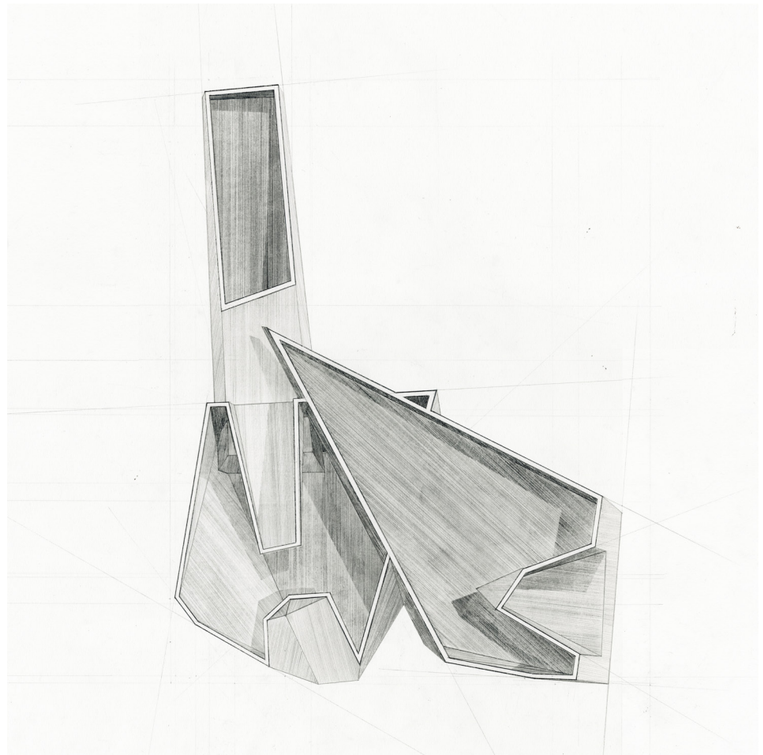
These same transformations were taken to a physical form. In a set of nine physical models that represented the same operations of intersection, simple geometries collide to generate more complex figures.

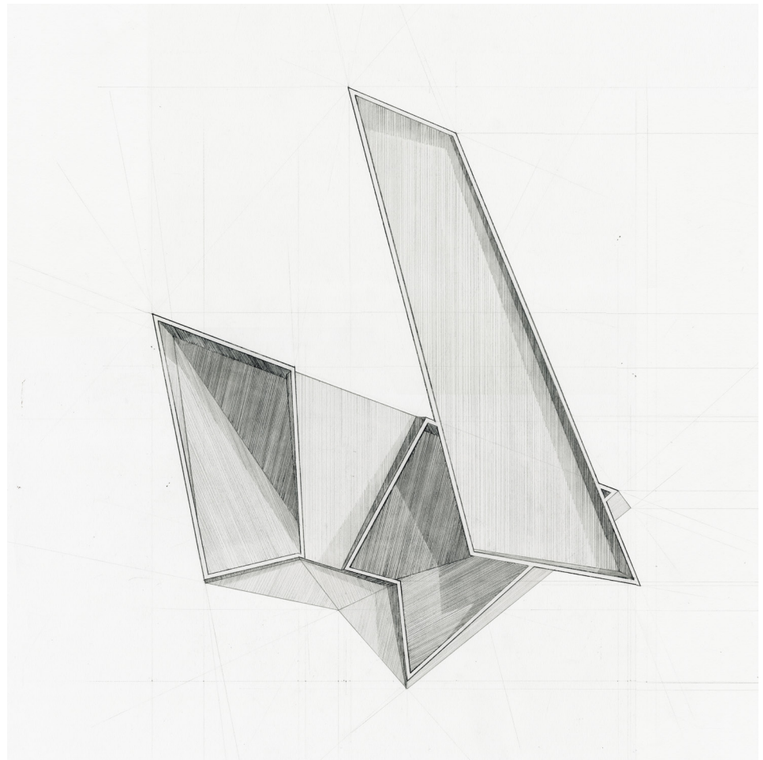






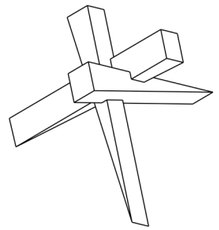
The final models were produced from a continuation of the operations from the original 2 series. In focusing on how the base geometry of a quadrilateral prism can be deformed and intersected to create both volume and voids, the final form appears.



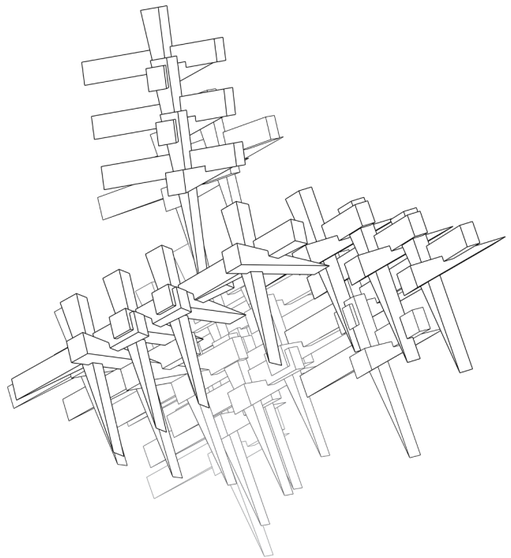


Orthogonal section cuts derived from the physical massing model to investigate its internal spatial logic. Executed by hand, these drawings utilize directional hatching to articulate volumetric depth, establishing a clear hierarchy between the solid exterior planes and the revealed interior cavities.

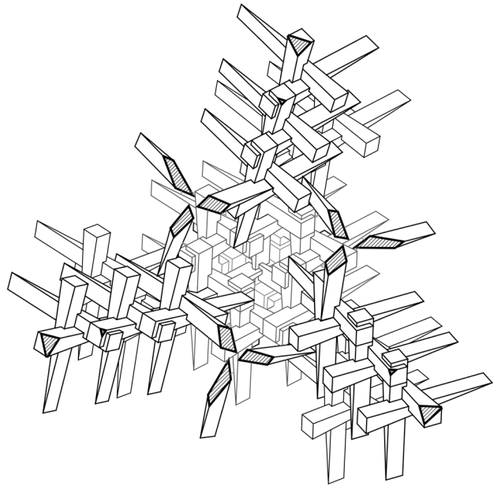
02 TOTEM

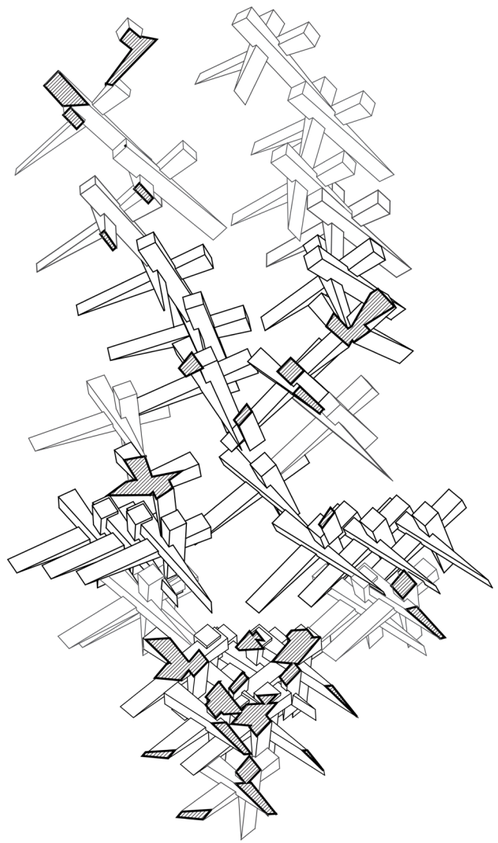


Totem explores the concepts of geometric and systematic evolution that generates an overall organization in which the whole is greater than the sum of its parts.



This project explores the aggregation of a singular base unit composed of three intersecting triangular prisms through a dual system of joinery. The form charts a vertical transition in structural logic: shifting from a heavy, orthogonally interlocked base to a delicate, surface-resting condition at the apex. This gradual release of joint rigidity results in a progressively lighter, expanding spatial canopy.



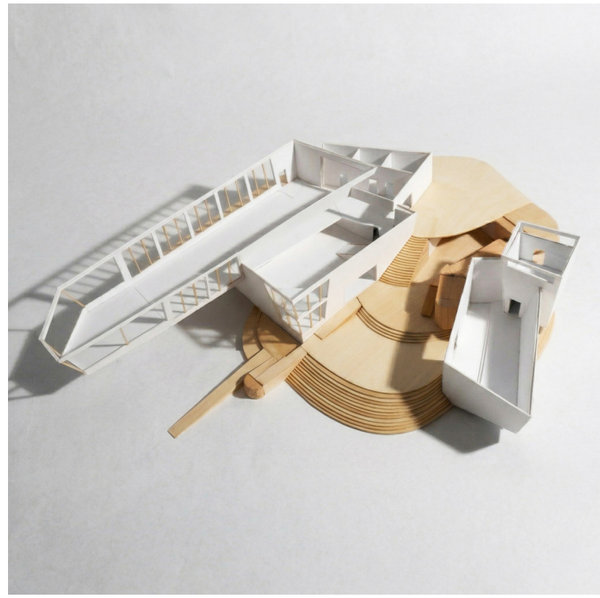


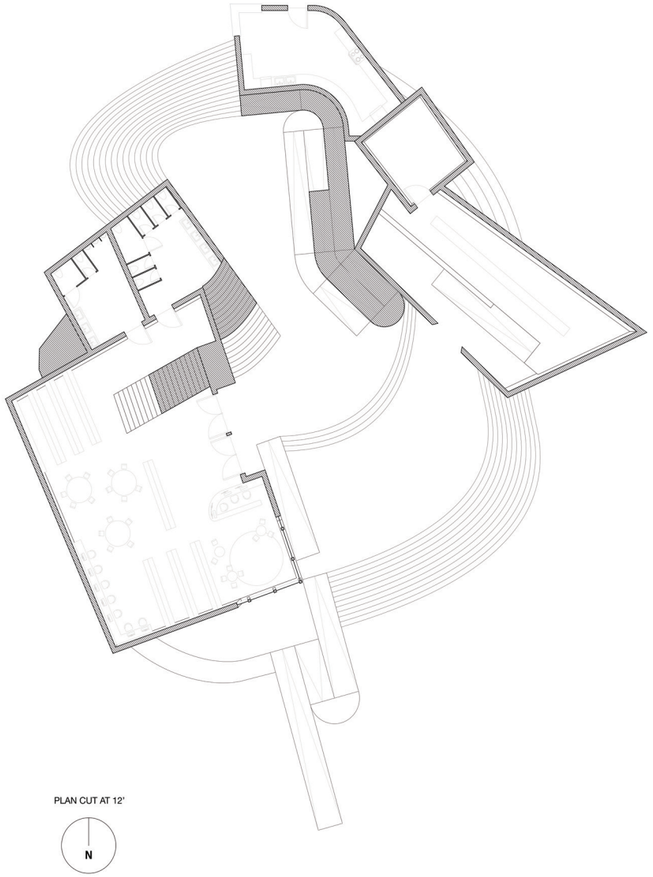
Top: Plan, cut at 1'0"

Bottom: Section

03 MFAH LIBRARY

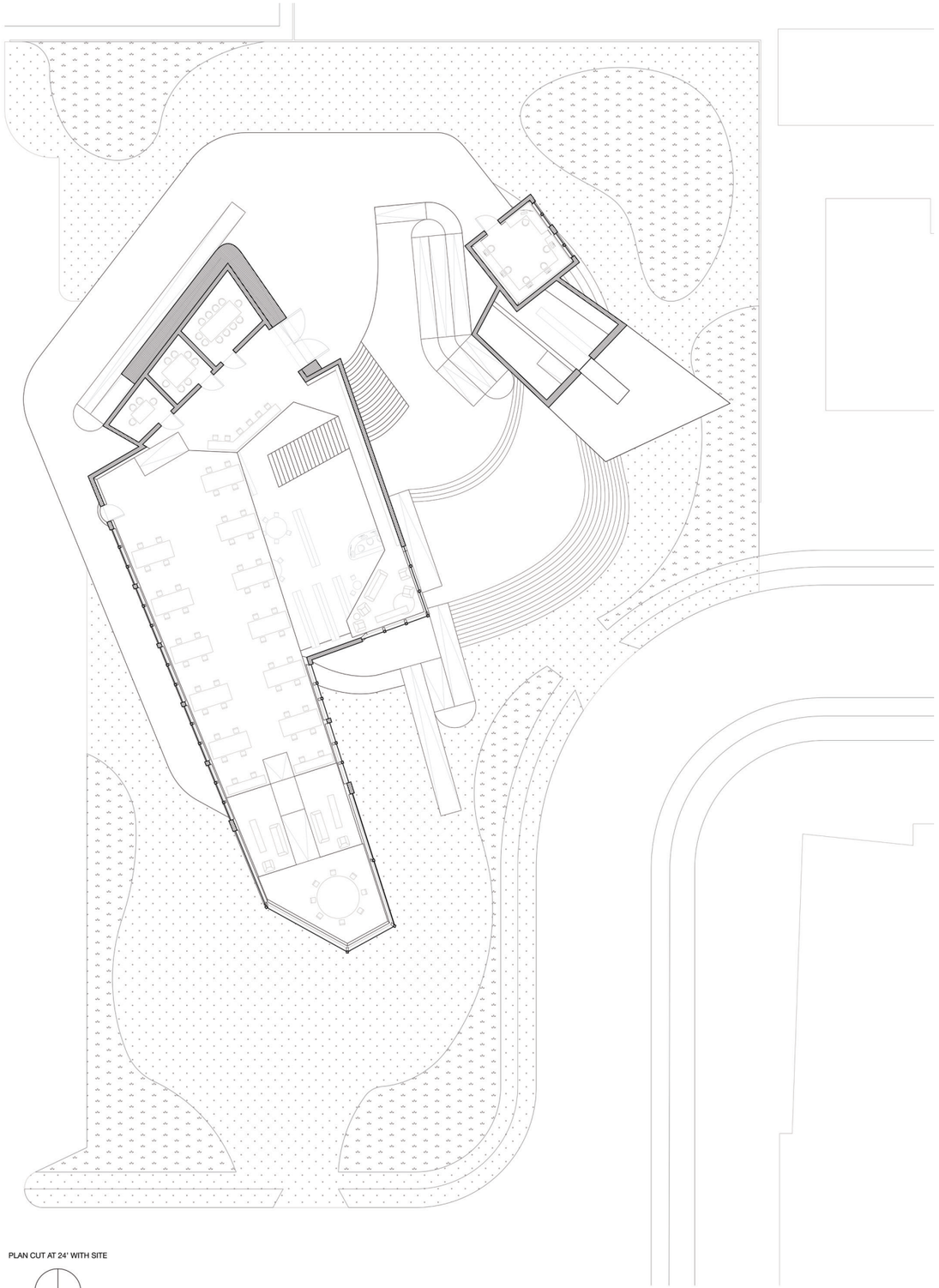
In the MFAH expansion, students were asked to extend the campus of the Museum of Fine Arts, Houston by adding a library to a vacant lot Northeast of the Glassell School of Art. This expansion was expected to be a library with program elements such as an exhibition gallery, fine art book collection, and children's area. Furthermore, inspiration was to be taken from Totem and Geometric Abstractions.





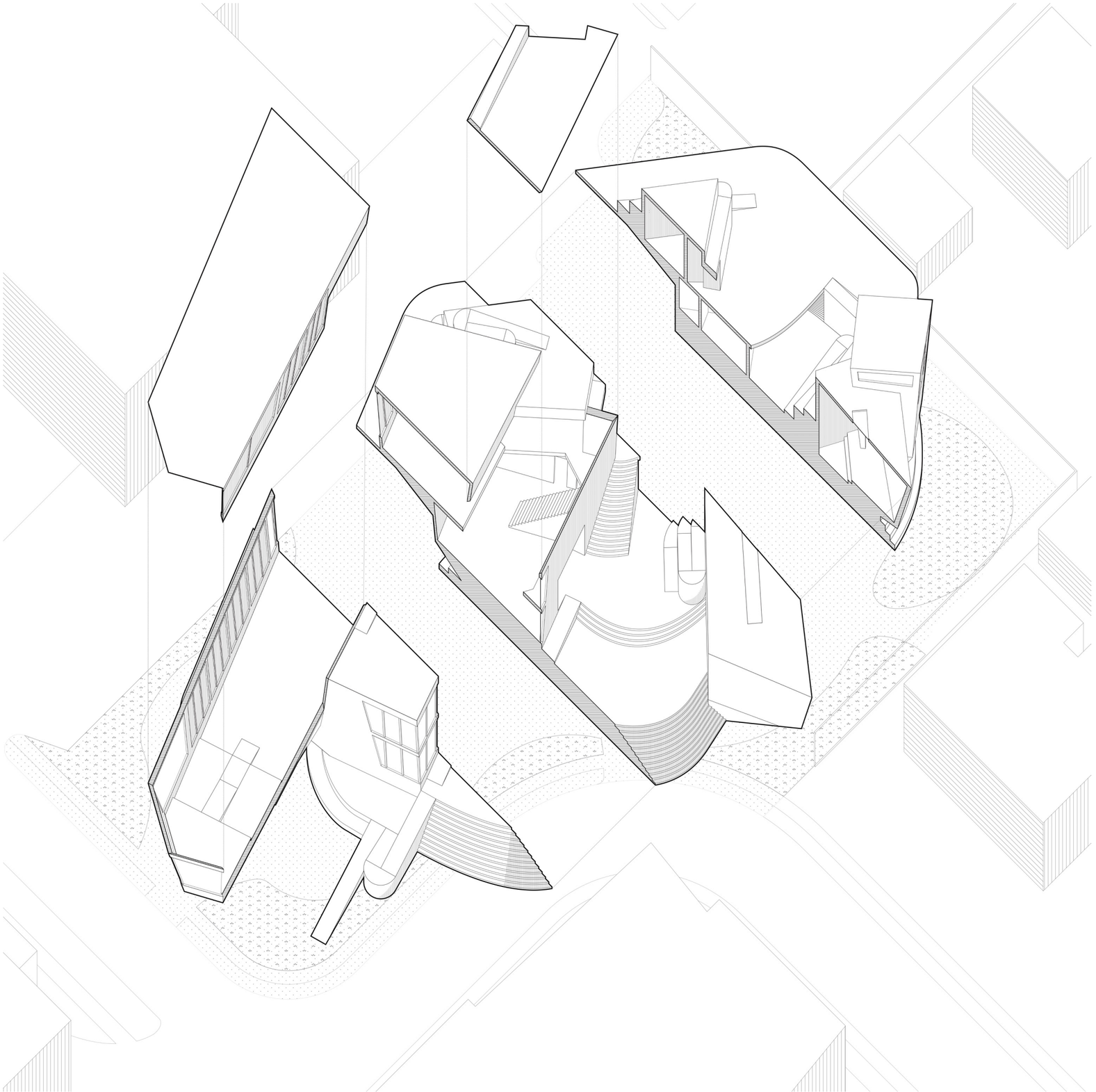
PLAN CUT AT 12'

N



PLAN CUT AT 24' WITH SITE

N



The spatial sequence of the project utilizes a series of irregular quadrilaterals derived directly from the Abstraction of Geometries study to generate an interplay between solid mass and open void. The structural liberation of the ground plane is guided by precedents like Diller Scofidio + Renfro's ICA Boston and OMA's Milstein Hall.

The internal logic of the architecture relies on fracturing the footprint into distinct structures, which allows the ground plane to remain porous, introducing terraced outdoor platforms that sit between the buildings.

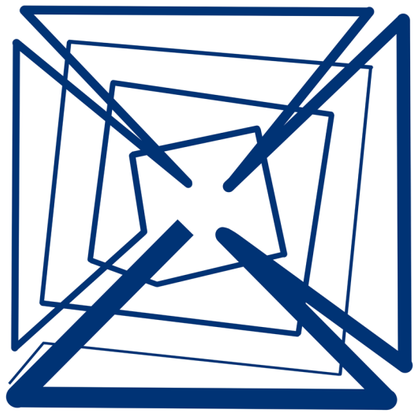
Subverting traditional programming, the spatial hierarchy dictates that the program becomes increasingly public as one moves vertically through the building. This upward trajectory culminates in the dramatic cantilevered volume—an expansive, hanging public space hovering above the site that acts as the ultimate social condenser, while simultaneously sheltering the pedestrian landscape below.

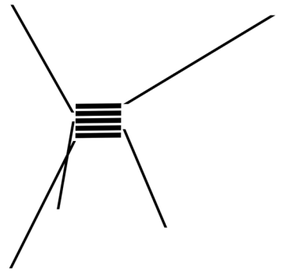
04 EXTERNAL SYSTEMS

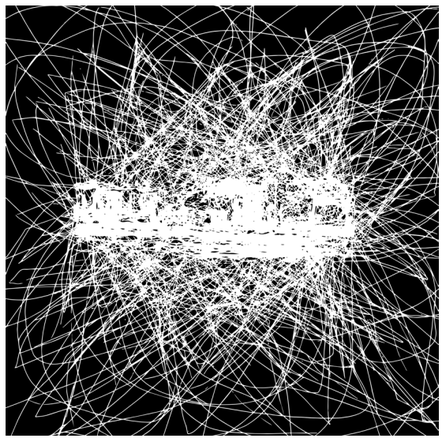
This assignment focused on the understanding of qualities that shape and impact building form, massing, surface, and space.

The first part of the assignment was a scalar mapping project of Michael Heizer's 45, 90, 180 sculpture series, with a focus on the 180 element. This three-part analysis iteratively expands from a single perspective to a hundred: a lone nighttime view looking through the sculpture's core gap; a ten-image grid analyzing materiality and its echoes across campus architecture; and a hundred-image radial survey documenting the sculpture within the engineering quad.

The final photo is a layered composite of one hundred radial photographs taken in the engineering quad, iteratively stacking space and time into a single color field.

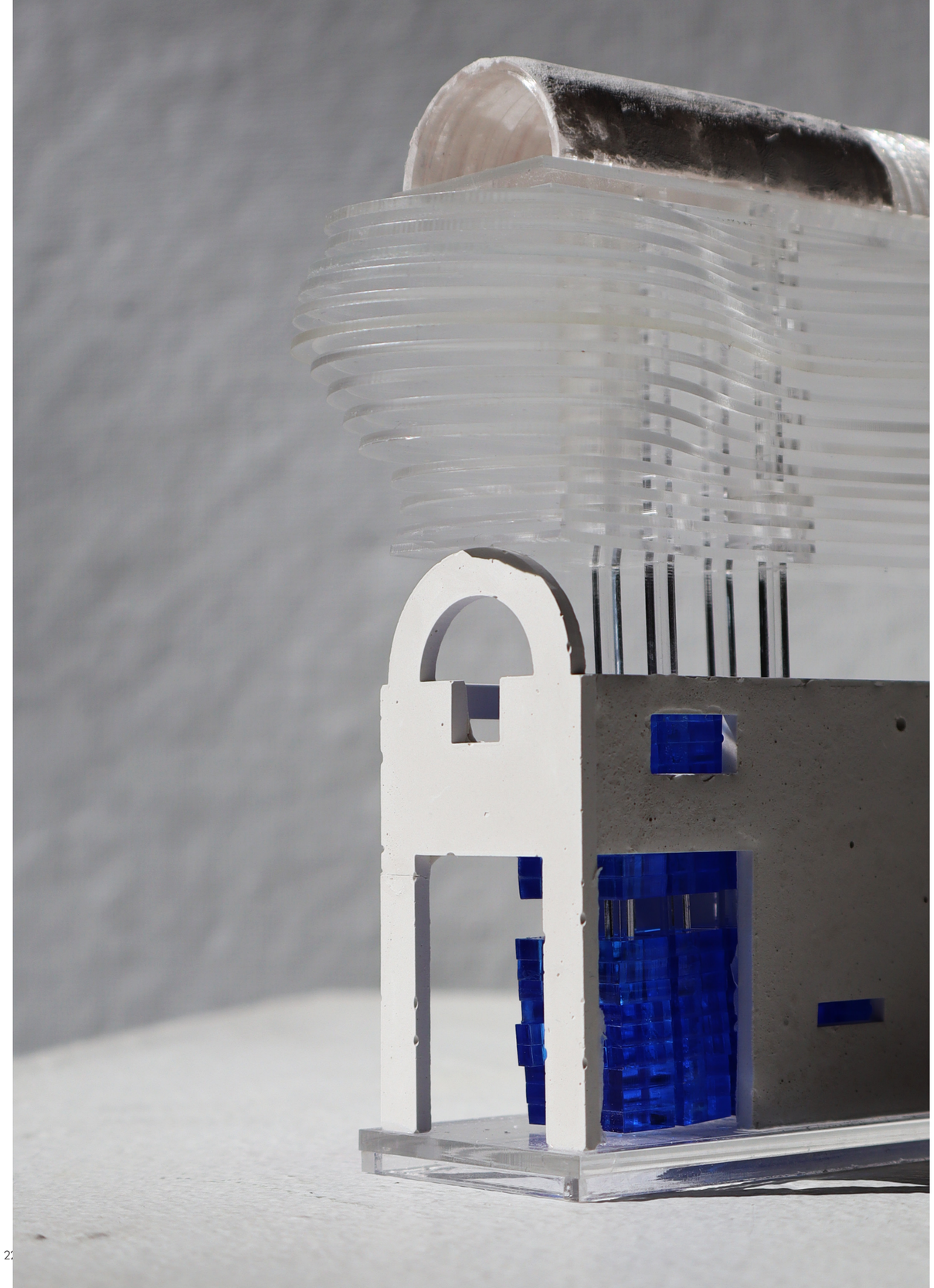




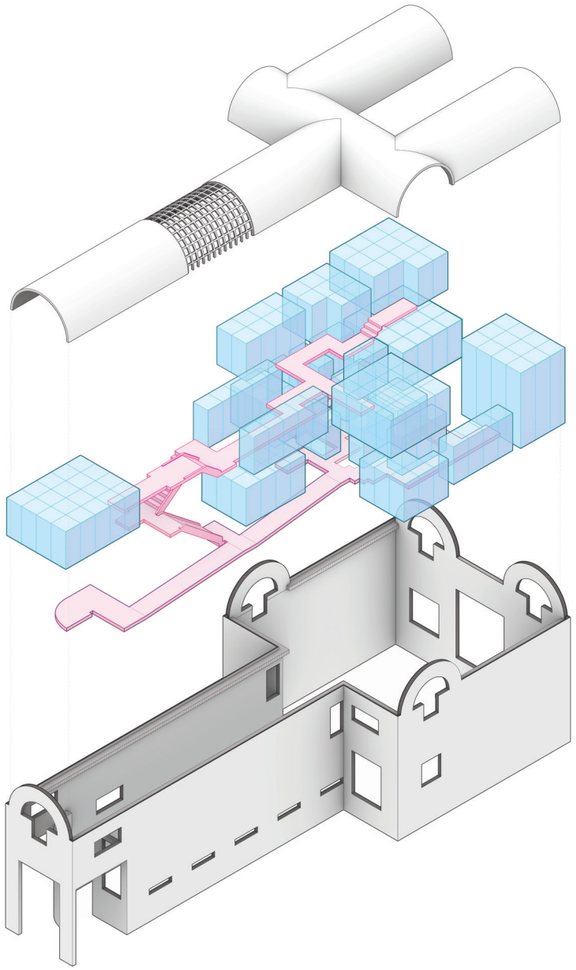


The second part of the assignment consisted of mapping our photos with 1 line, 10 lines, and 100 lines.

The series consists of a single continuous line tracing the physical path of the radial survey; ten vectors pointing to sites of material equivalence across campus; and one thousand lines tracking five minutes of my eye movement across a single photograph. The study culminates in a final, algorithmic composite mapping of all one hundred images, digitally isolated into high-contrast zones of saturation and lightness.

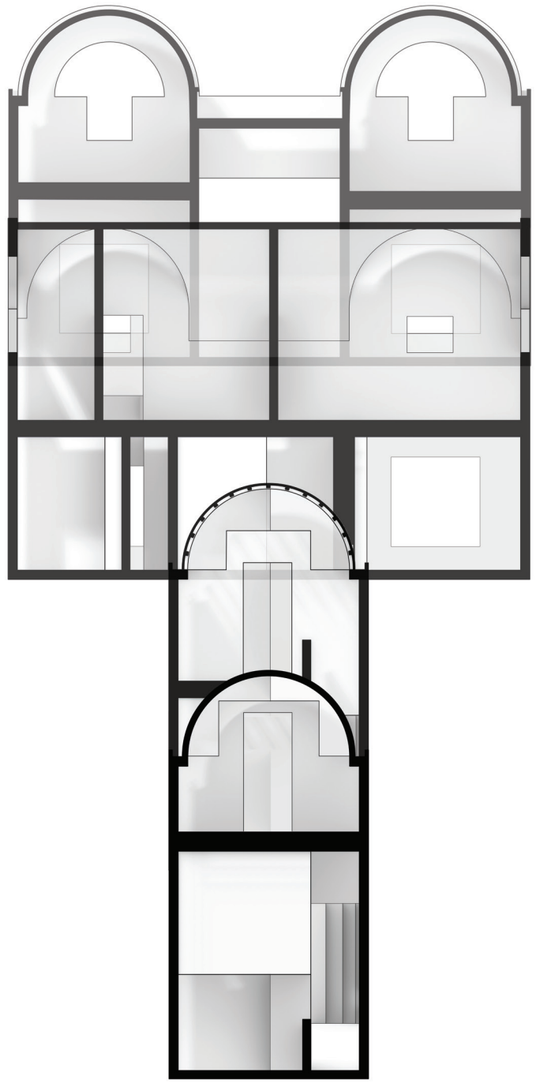


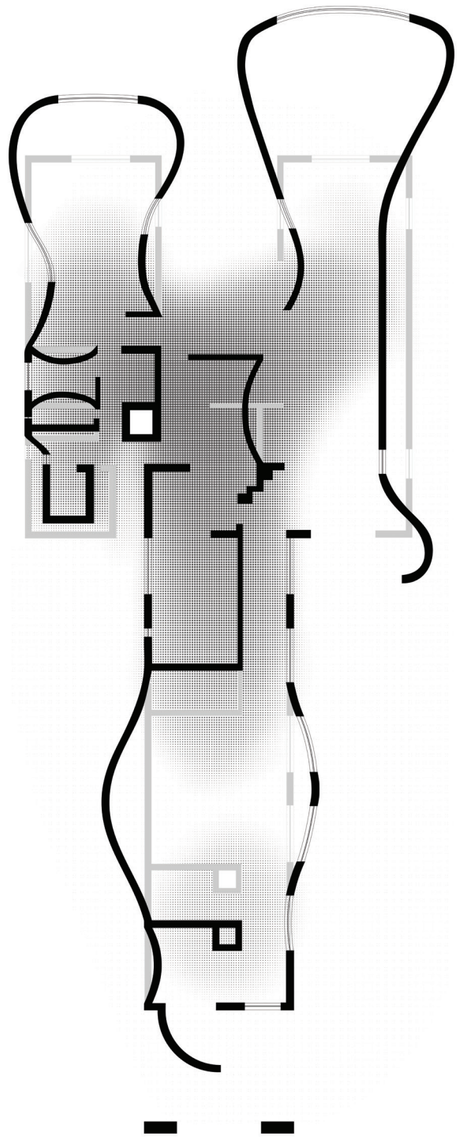
05 INTERNAL SYSTEMS

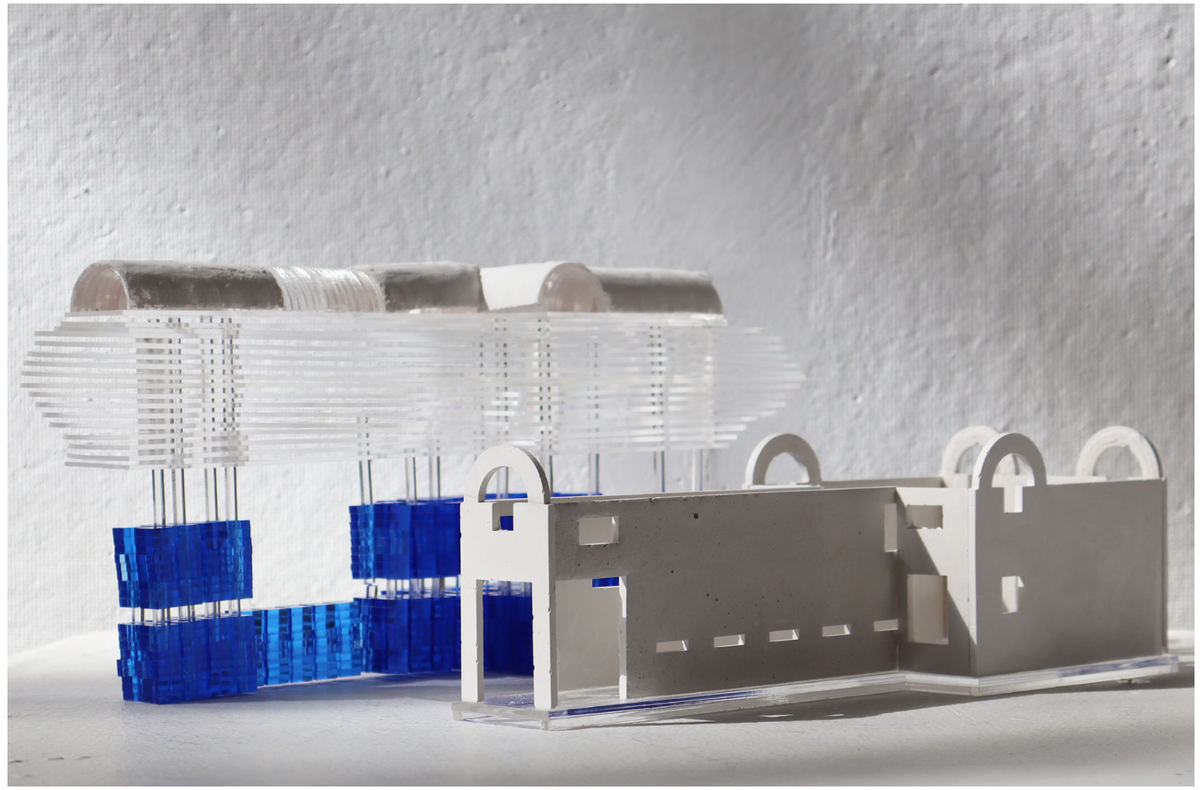


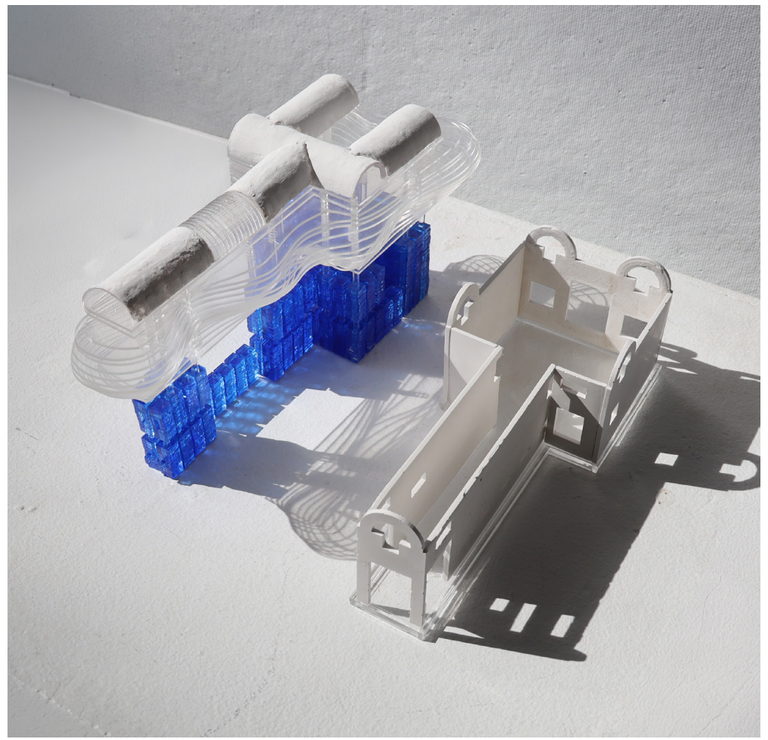
This assignment is a precedent study of Arata Isozaki's Hayashi House, focusing on the juxtaposition between the building's interior and exterior. The design highlights the contrast between a winding, flexible, and modular interior and the rigid, cave-like exterior that encases it.

To analyze this juxtaposition, I produced a series of drawings: an axonometric drawing revealing how branching circulation creates an expansive interior feel; a layered section cut highlighting spatial variations beneath consistent vaulted ceilings; and a distorted plan mapping how natural light pierces the solid exterior through clerestories and skylights.







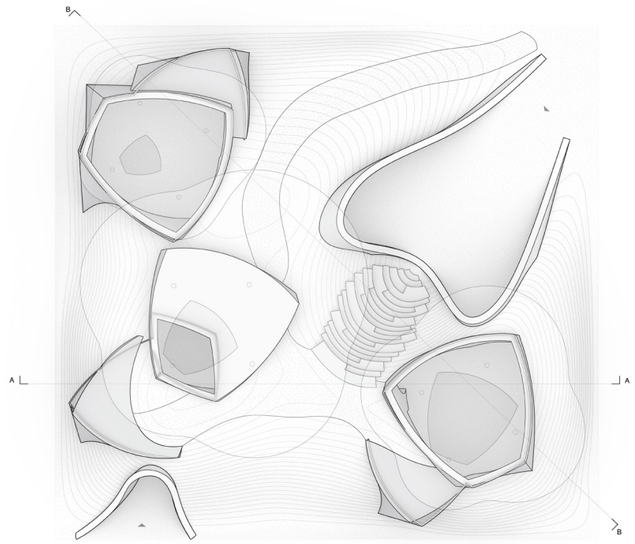


Left: Layered section-cuts

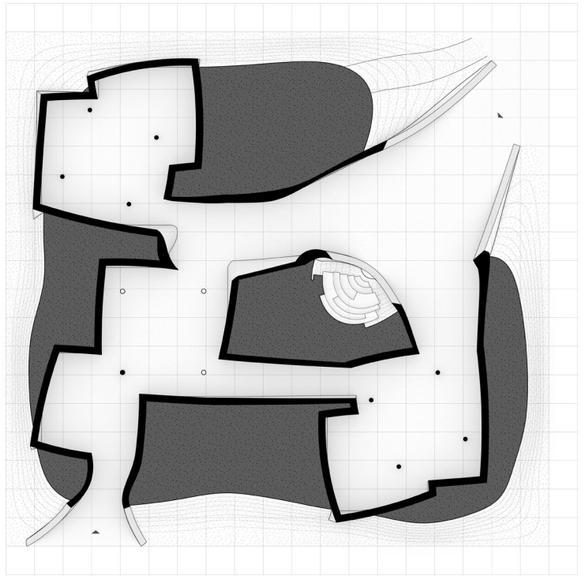
Bottom: Light-distorted plan

I then synthesized these concepts into a final acrylic and plaster model that physically captures the project's modularity, vaulted forms, and dynamic interplay of light.

06 MENIL EXTENSION



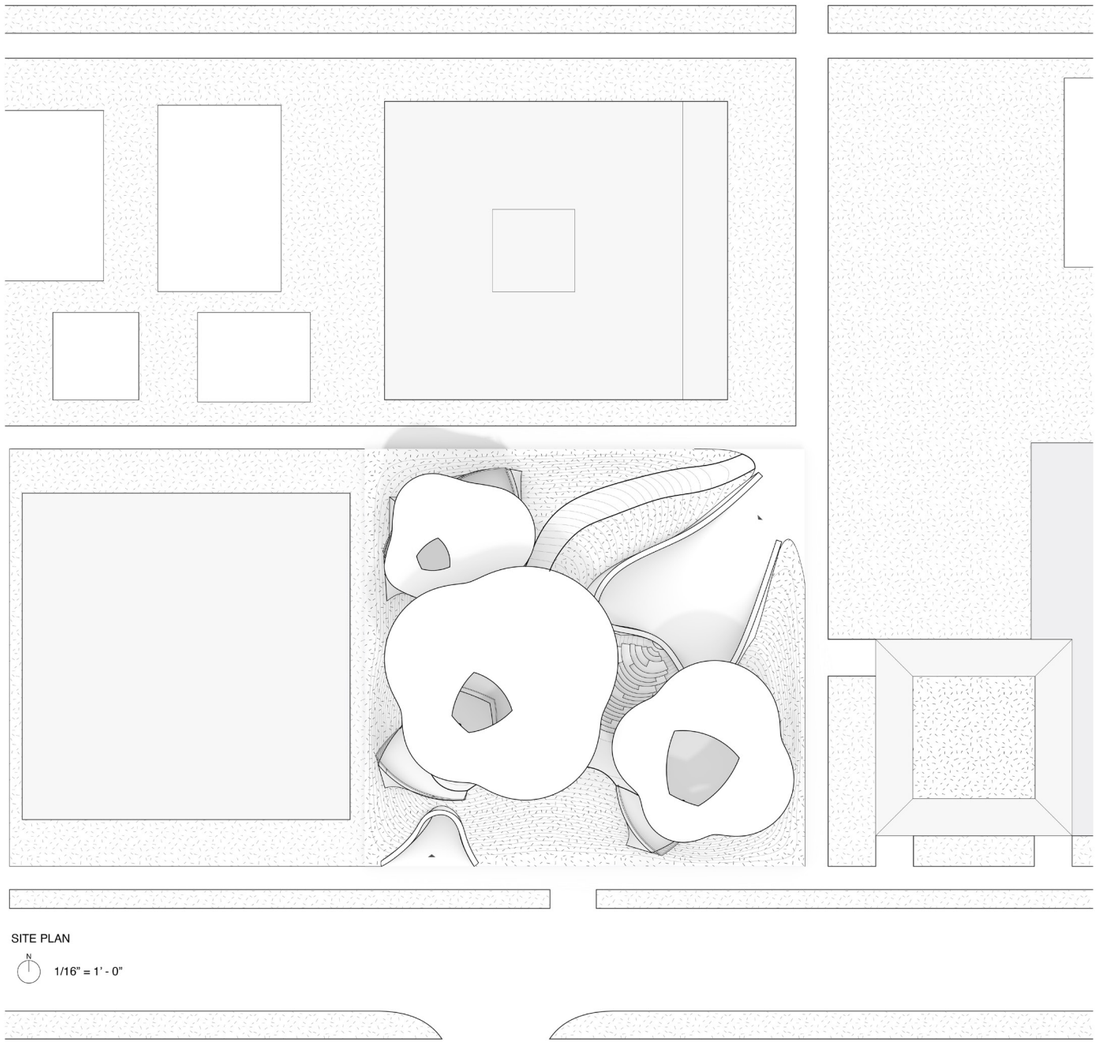
HILLTOP PLAN
N
1/8" = 1' - 0"



PLAN
N
1/8" = 1' - 0"

Designed as an exploration of intersecting systems, this architectural extension is located directly on the Menil campus. The structure functions as a dynamic pavilion that links the gap between the built environment and the surrounding landscape.

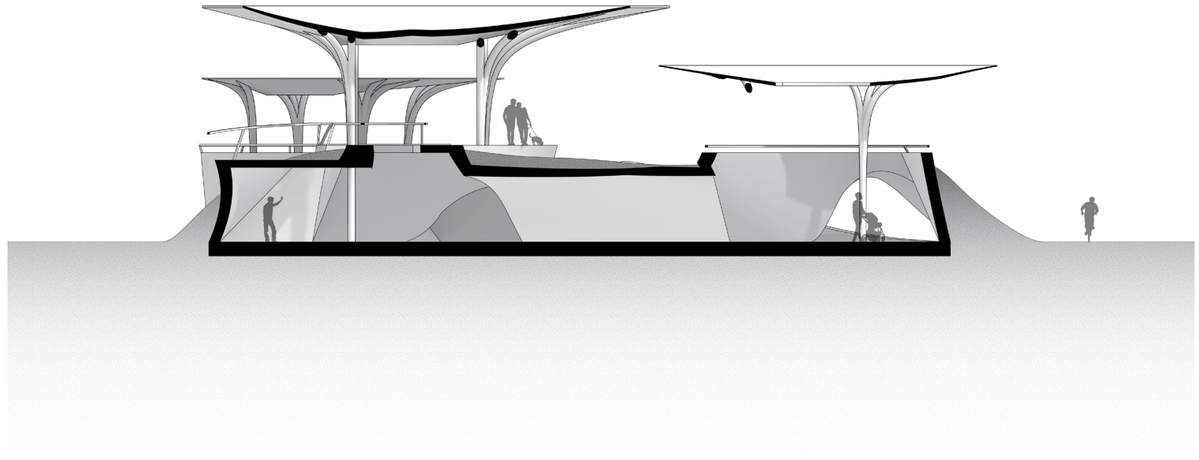
The core concept is anchored by a grid, which is mapped directly from the circulation paths of the existing campus buildings. By overlapping these established pedestrian flows, the extension integrates into the site, ensuring seamless movement and accessibility for visitors.



SITE PLAN

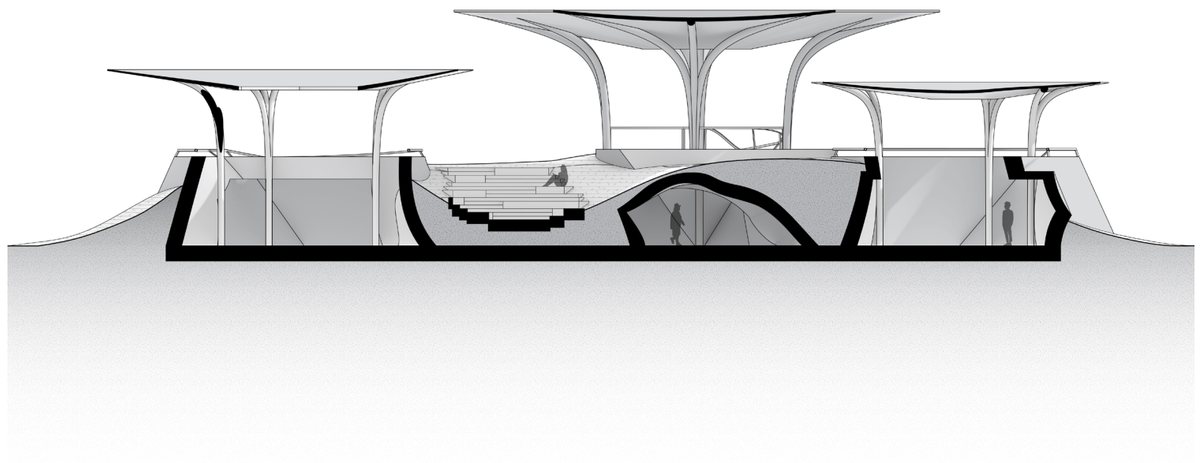
N

1/16" = 1' - 0"



SECTION A

1/8" = 1' - 0"

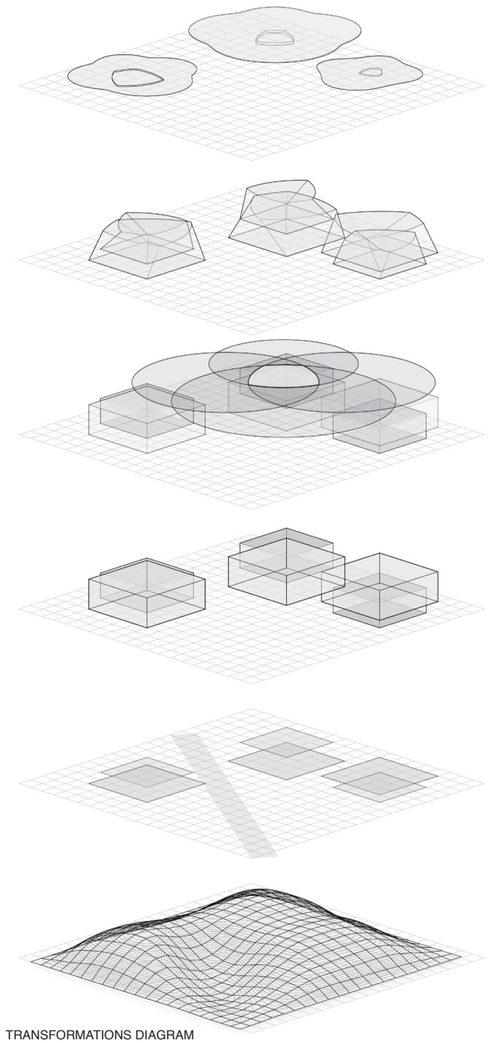


SECTION B

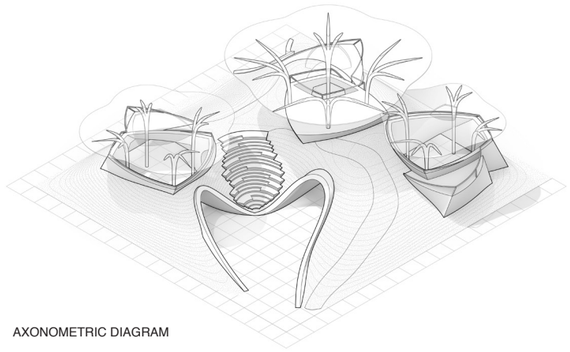
1/8" = 1' - 0"

The architectural shape language responds to the immediate context by referencing the concentric squares found on the roofs of the adjacent Drawing Institute and Cy Twombly Gallery. This geometric motif is modified through the introduction of circular forms, producing a curvilinear shape that softens the rigidity of the site.

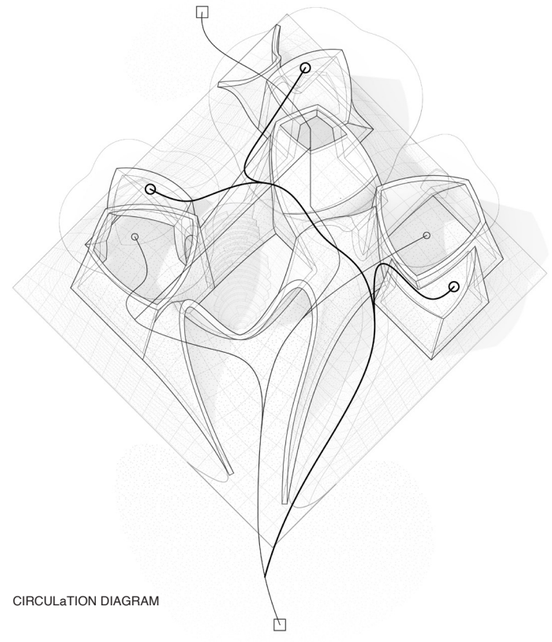
This curvilinear motif flows downward into the structural grid, generating a biometric indoor condition. Above, the natural landscape sweeps over the structural "bones" of the building, which maximizes green space and allows the sweeping rooflines and the rolling terrain to act as mirrored reflections of one another.



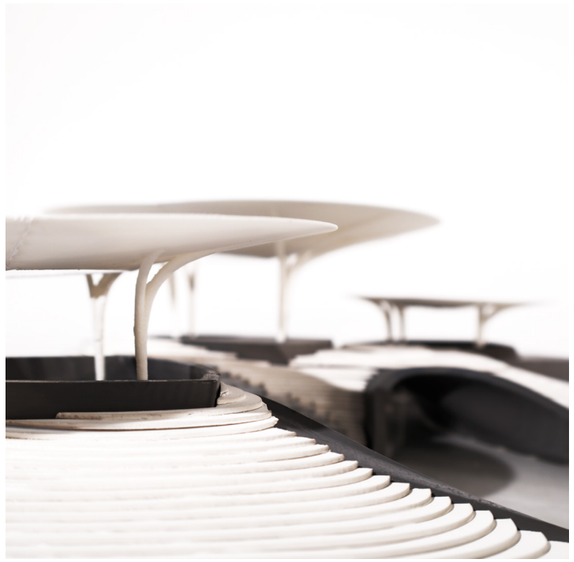
TRANSFORMATIONS DIAGRAM



AXONOMETRIC DIAGRAM



CIRCULaTION DIAGRAM



Functionally, the pavilion features a freeform approach to its internal programming. To meet the diverse requirements of the project, the layout is divided into three distinct indoor rooms and one outdoor gathering area. This flexible arrangement allows the extension to be easily molded to whatever functional needs arise on campus.

These interconnected areas offer varying degrees of exposure to nature, accommodating both large public interactions and intimate, private moments. By balancing enclosed environments with open-air spaces, the pavilion becomes a versatile, adaptable, and highly integrated addition to the site.